
St. Augustine's Method of Composing and Delivering Sermons

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I.—ST. AUGUSTINE'S METHOD OF COMPOSING AND DELIVERING SERMONS.

I. INTRODUCTION.

This article is the outgrowth of an investigation suggested to the author several years ago by Dean A. F. West of the Graduate School of Princeton University. At that time it was the author's intention to investigate only those sermons of Augustine on the Gospel and Epistle of Saint John, a short summary of which the author published in the Transactions and Proceedings of the American Philological Association of 1916. However, on looking over other sermons, he found the same characteristics existing generally throughout, and there seemed no good reason for confining the investigation to a small proportion of the discourses which did not differ particularly from all the rest. Accordingly the scope of the study was enlarged, and all the sermons of Augustine were examined with the present subject in view.

Throughout this study the author makes constant use of the terms "extempore" and "strictly extempore." By "extempore" he means that the sermons were probably given after some previous meditation on the subject, but with no extensive preparation. By "strictly extempore" he means that the sermons were given unexpectedly and without any preparation of any kind.

Among the church fathers, the terms *sermones*, *homiliae*, *tractatus*, *enarrationes*, etc., were used interchangeably for the

most part;¹ and in this study, "sermons," "homilies," "tractates," "commentaries," etc., are employed in like manner.

II. THE HITHERTO ACCEPTED VIEW.

The sermons of Saint Augustine have been divided by the Benedictine editors^{1a} (Th. Blampin, P. Constant, and others) into five classes, of which the first contains eighty-three upon various passages of the Old Testament, the second eighty-eight upon the great festivals of the year, the third sixty-nine upon the festivals of the saints, the fourth twenty-three upon a variety of subjects, and the fifth thirty-one of doubtful authenticity.² To this number should be added the explanations of the Psalms (*enarrationes in psalmos*) and of the Gospel and Epistle of John (*in Johannis evangelium tractatus 124, in Johannis epistolas tractatus 19*), besides a small number distributed throughout this collection, and others since discovered and published. Altogether there is left us from Augustine a corpus of about four hundred sermons.

It has been said, more or less categorically, that Augustine wrote most of his sermons before he delivered them, that he dictated many to be read thereafter, and that he delivered some extemporaneously, these last being taken down by stenographers (*notarii*) in the church, and later transcribed into longhand.³ Manifestly the difference between writing and dictating sermons is very slight, since it is the difference merely between having some one put your careful thought in writing for you, and performing the manual labor yourself.⁴ Thus the current opinion resolves itself into the belief that Augustine prepared and wrote his sermons carefully before he delivered them, and

¹ Cf. Ferrarius, *De Ritu Concionum Sacrarum*, 1, 2.

^{1a} Paris 1679-1700, 11 folio volumes; Migne, P. L. 32-47, 1845-1849.

² Many other sermons have since been identified as genuine; cf. Ceillier, *Histoire des Auteurs sacrés et ecclésiastiques*, 9, 828; Morin, *Revue Bénédictine*, *passim*.

³ Cf. Benedictine edition, introduction to sermons; Ceillier, *op. cit.*, 9, 235; Morin, *Textes études et Découvertes*, 255; Bardenhewer, *Patrologie*, 430; Teuffel, *Roemische Literatur*, 36, 375; Degert, *Quid ad mores ingeniaque Afrorum****, 17, and others.

⁴ Cf. Norden, *Die antike Kunstprosa*, 22, 953; Ferrarius, *De Ritu Concionum Sacrarum*, 208.

only on rare occasions, generally due to some fortuitous circumstance, spoke extempore. We pass over the idea expressed occasionally that Augustine may have written or dictated his sermons after having preached them, because this is a mere supposition, and the character of such sermons would not differ especially from discourses written before delivery.

The chief source for the belief that Augustine wrote many of his sermons is the last sentence of the *Retractations*.⁵ This passage, however, involves a faulty text, which according to the preferred reading gives no support whatsoever to this opinion. The passage as given by the Benedictine edition and as utilized to support the idea in question is:

Haec opera XCIII in libris CCXXXII me dictasse recolui, quando haec retractavi . . . , atque ipsam eorum retractationem in libris II edidi . . . antequam epistulas et sermones in populum, *alios dictatos alios a me dictos, retractare coepissem*.

The latest edition of the *Retractations* by Knoll,⁶ whose new study of the MSS. has been warmly supported by Harnack,⁷ makes a very important change in this text. Instead of *alios dictatos*, Knoll reads *alias dictatas*. That is instead of saying, "before I began to look over my letters and sermons to the people, some (of the sermons) dictated and others (of the sermons) spoken," Augustine says, "before I began to look over my letters and sermons to the people, the former (the letters) dictated and the latter (the sermons) spoken."⁸ This new rendering would exclude any of Augustine's sermons as having been read before their delivery, and would stamp his discourses as being essentially of one sort. In writing his letters, Augustine, being a

⁵ 2, 93, 2.

⁶ *Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum*, Wien, 36, 1902.

⁷ *Die Retractationen Augustins*, Sitz. der Berliner Akademie, 1905, 1096.

⁸ This use of *alius* for *alter* is rare in classical Latin, but common in the speech of the people of every period. After the classical period, however, *alius* for *alter* became common in the literature also, e. g. Plin. nat. 11, 59 *duo genera apum, aliarum . . . aliarum . . .*, and Liv. I, 21, 6, *Ita duo deinceps reges, alius alia via, ille bello hic pace, civitatem auferunt*. This usage continued into the Latin of the church fathers. Cf. also Fr. Stolz u. J. H. Schmalz, *Lateinische Grammatik* 629.

very busy man and following the custom of his time, made use of stenographers;⁹ on the other hand, he spoke his sermons unhampered, and did not read his discourses after having previously written or dictated them.¹⁰

The only other possible evidence that Augustine ever wrote a sermon before or after its delivery is in the *De Doctrina Christiana* (4, 29), and in the *De Trinitate* (15, 48). In the former passage, Augustine says: "Sunt sane quidem qui bene pronuntiare possunt, quid autem pronuntient excogitare non possunt. Quod si ab aliis sumant eloquenter sapienterque conscriptum, memoriae quae commendent, atque ad populum proferant; si eam personam gerunt, non improbe faciunt." Why should we in any way believe from such a passage that Augustine wrote any of his sermons before or after having delivered them? To be sure it shows that Augustine was willing to have his sermons used by others, and, we may presume, was willing to see his discourses put in writing for that purpose, but this passage gives no more ground for saying that Augustine wrote his sermons than does the mere fact of the existence of his sermons in writing today. Why could not Augustine, after he had delivered his discourses, have had them transcribed into longhand from shorthand copies made by the *notarius* at the very moment of their delivery?

In his work on the Trinity,¹¹ Augustine mentions a subject already discussed in a sermon which was written up after its delivery. Here, as in the last sentence of the *Retractations*, he speaks of the sermon as *dictum*, and here, as apparently he does elsewhere,¹² Augustine uses *conscribere* to signify the transcribing of the notarius's shorthand copy into longhand. Granting

⁹ Cf. Chapter VI.

¹⁰ It is astonishing that Kroll and Skutsch (*Teuffel, Geschichte der römischen Literatur*, 3^e, 440, 12) should quote this sentence from the *Retractations* in its revised form to support their statement (i. e. the view accepted hitherto) that some of Augustine's sermons were dictated and some were written. They are apparently unaware of the importance of the change in reading, and far from accurate in interpreting the earlier text.

¹¹ 15, 48. Id quod de hac re in sermone quodam proferendo ad aures populi Christiani diximus, dictumque conscripsimus.

¹² Cf. Chapter VI.

that in this case Augustine himself performed the manual labor, which is most unlikely, the passage does not mean that Augustine sat down after he delivered the sermon and wrote it up as best he could from memory, or from any notes from which he may have preached. The sermon, as will be seen later, bears too many striking marks of spontaneity and naturalness to admit of such a composition.

Having, we hope, thus disposed of any belief that Augustine, according to existing evidence, wrote sermons before or after he delivered them, we are ready to take up the main subject of this investigation: How did Augustine compose and deliver his sermons, and incidentally how have these discourses come down to us?

III. THE COMPOSITION OF SERMONS AS REVEALED IN THE WORKS OF CONTEMPORANEOUS AND NEARLY CONTEMPORANEOUS CHURCH FATHERS.

The early fathers of the church used all of the various ways of composing and delivering sermons.¹ It often happened that bishops, through being sick or in exile, or from other causes, were unable to fulfill their special duty of preaching.² Rather than let any of their subordinates preach for them, they frequently would write sermons in the form of letters to be read to the various congregations. Athanasius, John Chrysostom, and Cyprian, while in exile, all wrote sermons in the form of letters for their people. The second letter of Clemens Romanus, the first letter of Peter, that of James, as well as the Epistle to the Hebrews are sermons in letter form.³

Sermons were sometimes written by one person and delivered by another, either from memory or by the use of a written copy.⁴

¹ Cf. Ferrarius, *op. cit.* 105, 172.

² In the earlier centuries of the church, only bishops had the right to preach. Later, however, they extended this power to certain of their priests. The bishops of Rome clung to this privilege most zealously, and looked with a bad eye upon such as delegated this right to their subordinates. Cf. Duchesne, *Origines du culte chrétien*, 163.

³ Cf. Harnack, *Geschichte der altchristlichen Literatur bis Eusebius* 1; 438, 451, 487; Norden, *op. cit.* 618.

⁴ Ferrarius, *op. cit.* 203.

Thus Cyril of Alexandria says in the prologue of his twenty-second paschal sermon, "Not at all with a desire to display our eloquence have we put forth this little sermon or rather letter, but because of the old tradition were we induced to do it."⁵ Cassianus confirms what we would naturally conclude from these words, by saying specifically that Cyril's predecessor wrote sermons to be circulated and delivered by others. "In the region of Aegypt," he says, "that old custom is preserved of sending letters of the pontifex of Alexandria to all the churches. With these letters the beginning of Lent and Easter is ordained, not only throughout the cities, but also in all the monasteries. . . . In accordance with this custom . . . the blessed letters of Theophilus, bishop of the aforementioned city, were passed around."⁶ For a similar purpose, we read that Gaudentius, bishop of Brixia, sent his tractates to Benevolus,⁷ that Antiochus Monachus sent several homilies to Euthasius,⁸ and that Gregory the Great sent two codices of discourses to Secundinus.⁹ Pope Gregory the Great often had his sermons read to the people by *notarii*, as we learn from the beginning of his letter to Secundinus, when he writes, "During the holy sacrifices of the mass, I have expounded forty readings of the Holy Gospel which are usually read in this church on certain days. And the explanations of some, dictated previously, were recited by a *notarius* in the presence of the people. The interpretations of others, I myself delivered before the people, and my words were taken down as I spoke."¹⁰ Also in homily 21, Gregory says, "Regarding my preaching, my dear brethren, I have been accustomed to speak to you, after having previously had my words taken down from dictation. However, since I myself am unable to read these because of a weak stomach, I notice that some of you are less willing to give attention. Wherefore I now intend, contrary to my wont, to bring myself to explain the reading of the Holy Gospel in the mass, not through dictation, but by an informal talk. And as we speak,

⁵ P. G. 77, 857.⁷ P. L. 20, 827.⁶ Collatio 10, 2; P. L. 49, 820.⁸ P. G. 89, 1421.⁹ P. L. 77, 990.¹⁰ Cf. Pfeilschifter, *Die authentische Ausgabe der Evangelien-Homilien Gregors des Grossen*.

let it be taken down, because the voice of one talking informally stirs the sleeping heart more than the words of a reader, and, as it were, with an anxious hand, prods them to attention.”¹¹ According to Gennadius, Cyril of Alexandria wrote many sermons which he caused to be sent to all the bishops of Greece, and which they memorized and delivered as their own.¹²

Caesarius of Arles played a very exceptional role as a composer of homilies for others. The contemporary biographers of Caesarius all declare that during his episcopate of more than half a century, he was not content to speak himself nearly every day, but his zeal for the word of God and the instruction of the Christian people, brought him to compose and have composed many collections of sermons for the use of other preachers. These compilations, of which he always had a supply on hand, he not only gave out to willing ecclesiastics, but he even forced the unwilling to take them as they passed through Arles. Moreover, he even exported some to the farthestmost parts of the Gauls, Italy, and Spain. These collections usually consisted of extracts from Augustine, Ambrose, and other fathers, arranged and put within the grasp of the people, with bits of material entirely original which Caesarius scattered throughout, particularly at the beginning and end.¹³

Throughout the *De Doctrina Christiana*, Augustine assumes speaking, and that, too, largely extempore, and not reading, as the proper mode of delivering a sermon, and yet he makes allowances for those who have not the ability to compose well, and who accordingly make use of the composition of others. He tells us that a preacher may deliver to the people what has been written by a man more eloquent than himself.¹⁴ He says too, “But whether a man is going to address the people or dictate what others will deliver or read to the people, he ought to pray God to put into his mouth a suitable discourse. . . . Those, again, who are to deliver what others compose for them

¹¹ Cf. also Joannes Diaconus, *Gregorii Vita*, 2, 18 and 4, 74.

¹² Gennadius, *De illustribus ecclesiae scriptoribus*, 58: Cyrillus Alexandrinae ecclesiae episcopus homilias composuit plurimas, quae ad declamandum a Graecis memoriae commendantur.

¹³ Cf. Arnold, Caesarius von Arelate; Morin, *Revue Bénédictine*, passim.

¹⁴ *De Doctrina Christiana*, 4, 62.

ought, before they receive their discourse, to pray for those who are preparing it; and when they have received it, they ought to pray both that they themselves may deliver it well, and that those to whom they address it, may give ear."¹⁵ In speaking thus of those who will deliver or who will read, Augustine of course has in mind those who will memorize and then deliver sermons, and those who will merely read what others have composed. Surely it is not to be conjectured from these remarks that Augustine is making a defence of a practice in which he himself sometimes indulged. He is clearly making a concession to a method of discoursing, which is wholly out of place and in no way conformable to the principles that he himself lays down in his discussion of the art of preaching (i. e. in the *De Doctrina Christiana*).

In Atticus, bishop of Constantinople, we have a church father who, at least for a period of his activity, wrote out and then memorized his sermons before he delivered them.

The great minds of the patristic floruit (fourth and fifth centuries), however, usually preached extempore, or if not extempore in the strictest sense, after some meditation on the subject. Regarding Origen, Eusebius says: "At this time, as the faith extended and our doctrine was proclaimed boldly before all, Origen, being as they say, over sixty years old, and having gained great facility by his long practice, very properly permitted his public discourses to be taken down by stenographers, a thing which he had never before allowed."¹⁶

Cyril of Jerusalem likewise, on certain occasions at least, spoke extemporaneously. All of his Catecheses have the characteristics of extempore discourses, and, besides, the first of these sermons has the heading, "To those who are to be enlightened, delivered extempore at Jerusalem, as an introductory lecture to those who had come forward for Baptism."¹⁷

The homilies of John Chrysostom have many evidences of being extemporized discourses. They contain many utterances which are due to fortuitous and unexpected happenings, such

¹⁵ *De Doctrina Christiana*, 4, 63.

¹⁶ *Historia Ecclesiastica*, 6, 36, P. G. 20, 596. Cf. also Rufinus, P. L. 21; Nicephorus, 5, 19.

¹⁷ P. G. 33, 369.

as references to a congregation larger and noisier than usual, an unbecoming outburst of applause from the congregation, and similar things. On one occasion in particular, Socrates tells us that Chrysostom launched out on a denunciation against Epiphanius, who was just then entering the church and who, he had learned, was sent against him by the Empress Eudoxia.¹⁸ The same Chrysostom, having returned from exile, was forced by his overjoyed people to take his chair in the church, whereupon he addressed them purely extemporaneously.¹⁹ We also learn from Socrates that Chrysostom regularly had *notarii* in the church to take down his utterances. Socrates says, "Why need we speak of the sermons published by himself and those taken down by stenographers as he spoke, not only brilliant sermons, but very attractive ones?"²⁰

The sermons of Severian of Gabala have all the marks of spoken and largely extemporaneous discourses. They are full of short pointed remarks, many of them suggested by immediate and accidental circumstances. Severian for a time preached in Chrysostom's church, and Chrysostom's church-stenographers very likely took his sermons down also. It may be for this very reason that many of Severian's sermons are included in the collections of homilies by Chrysostom. Indeed there are many sermons among the spuria of the latter which very likely belong to the former.²¹

Socrates says of Atticus, bishop of Constantinople: "Formerly, while a presbyter, he had been accustomed, after composing his sermons, to commit them to memory, and then recite them in the church; but by diligent application, he acquired confidence and made his instruction extemporaneous and eloquent. His discourses, however, were not such as to be received with much applause by his auditors, or to deserve to be committed to writing."²²

¹⁸ *Historia Ecclesiastica* 6, 14, P. G. 67, 705.

¹⁹ Socrates, *Historia Ecclesiastica* 6, 16, P. G. 67, 712; Sozomenus 8, 18, P. G. 67, 1562; Nicephorus, 83, 16, P. G. 146, 985.

²⁰ Socrates, *Historia Ecclesiastica* 6, 4, P. G. 67, 672.

²¹ We are indebted, for this information, to H. T. Weiskotten, who is at present investigating the spuria of Chrysostom in connection with his study of Severian. [But see also Christ-Schmid-Stählin, *Griech. Litteraturgeschichte*, II, 25, 1227.—C. W. E. M.]

²² *Historia Ecclesiastica*, P. G. 67, 741.

Pope Faustus also preached extempore. This we learn from Sidonius Apollinaris, who wrote to him saying: "Often was it my privilege to listen as a hoarse applauder, now to your spontaneous sermons, now to your well prepared discourses, especially on those weekly feast-days in the holy church of Lyons, when you were prevailed upon to speak by your blessed colleagues."²³

Jerome's tractates on the Psalms have been very carefully investigated by A. S. Pease²⁴ and G. Morin.²⁵ Professor Pease says, in summary, "To suppose that Jerome wrote out before delivery all that we have here is to believe that he wrote much that was trivial and self-evident. A view more charitable to the ability of so great a man, and equally compatible with our evidence, is to believe that we have, not his notes, but the report (shorthand or otherwise) of a hearer who wrote down, to the best of his ability, all that Jerome said, important or unimportant, but very likely lost entirely many utterances of some value while he was engaged in setting down ideas of inferior importance (a phenomenon familiar in the college lecture-room of our own day). The more careful and scholarly sermons may be due to Jerome's revision (improved by frequent erasure) of the reporter's copy."

Thus, in this brief survey of contemporaneous and nearly contemporaneous writers, we find that those who acquired fame as eloquent preachers all delivered their sermons without any written assistance of any kind. They did not write their discourses out first, and then read them, but they spoke after first giving their theme a certain amount of meditation. Very often, too, they were led by special circumstances to speak wholly without preparation of any kind.

IV. THE PRESENCE OF NOTARII IN THE CHURCHES TO TAKE DOWN SERMONS WHEN THEY WERE BEING DELIVERED.¹

In Augustine's time stenographers were divided into three classes. The *notarii*, whose recognition as a separate class is

²³ 9, 3, 5.

²⁴ *Journal of Biblical Literature*, 26, 1907, 106-131.

²⁵ *Revue d'histoire et de littérature religieuse*, 1, 1896, 393-434; also *Études, Textes, et Découvertes*.

¹ Stenography as such is first definitely recognized in the history of

attributed to Clement (91-100 A. D.), wrote in shorthand from dictation or public speech, and were in the employment of church dignitaries. The *exceptores* also wrote in shorthand from dictation or public speech, and at least from the time of Augustine onward, were distinguished from the *notarii* merely by their being in the employment of state magistrates. The *librarii*, often called *amanuenses*, were regular transcribers of shorthand records into longhand. *Scriba* is the most general term for denoting a copyist of any sort and not as a rule signifying a knowledge of shorthand.²

The preservation of the homilies of the great preachers of the church, whose sermons bear such marks of spontaneity, can be satisfactorily explained only by the use of a shorthand system by men skilled in the same and present in the church for the express purpose of recording the spoken word. With any other explanation we would be giving in many cases scant credit for wisdom and thoughtfulness, and often a power of premonition and a remarkable, so to speak, histrionic sense.

There is an abundance of evidence, however, for the presence, both secret and public, of *notarii* actually at work during the delivery of sermons. We have already quoted a remark of Eusebius regarding Origen, that at sixty years of age he permitted his discourses to be taken down by stenographers.³ The catechetical sermons of Cyril of Jerusalem were taken down by earnest students as they were being delivered. For at the end of lecture 18, in the older of the Munich manuscripts, we read:

Latin literature with the appearance of the so-called "Tironian notes." After Tiro, the traditional founder of the system, freedman and friend of Cicero, the men most concerned with the development of stenography were Vipsanius Philargyrus (13 B. C.), Aquila (8 B. C.), a certain Seneca, probably the philosopher Lucius Annaeus (d. 65 A. D.) and lastly Cyprian, Bishop of Carthage (d. 258 A. D.). The system apparently went out of extensive use soon after the fifth century A. C., and, following the varying fortunes of learning, was revived in Carolingian times and again developed in the scholastic period. It was with the contemporaries and close successors of Cyprian (among whom of course is Augustine, 354-430 A. D.) that Roman stenography apparently reached its most general use.

² On the general subject, cf. Navarre, *Histoire générale de la sténographie*; Zimmermann, *Geschichte der Stenographie*.

³ Cf. Chap. II.

"Many other lectures were delivered year by year, both before Baptism and after the neophytes had been baptized. But these alone were taken down when spoken and written by some of the earnest students in the year 352 of the advent of Our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ."

In his sermon "The Last Farewell," Gregory Nazianzenus says, "Farewell, ye lovers of my discourses, in your eagerness and concourse, ye pencils seen and unseen, and thou balustrade, pressed upon by those who thrust themselves forward to hear the word."⁴ What else can the "pencils seen and unseen" mean than *notarii*, either secret or public, who were present to take down the words of Gregory?

The various biographers of Chrysostom tell us that skilled and trained *notarii* were always present, mingled with the audience, whenever he preached. Socrates says, "How eloquent, convincing, and persuasive his sermons were, both those which were published by himself, and such as were noted down by shorthand writers as he delivered them, why should we stay to declare? Those who desire to form an adequate idea of them, must read for themselves, and will thereby derive both pleasure and profit."⁵

Respecting Atticus, bishop of Constantinople, we have the statement of Socrates as well as those of Cassiodorus and Nicephorus. Socrates says, "Formerly while a presbyter, he had been accustomed, after composing his sermons, to commit them to memory, and then recite them in the church: but by diligent application he acquired confidence and made his instruction extemporaneous and eloquent. His discourses, however, were not such as to be received with much applause by his auditors, or to deserve to be committed to writing."⁶ Cassiodorus speaks more plainly regarding Atticus. He says, "Indeed at first when he was a presbyter, he wrote books and recited prepared subjects in the church. But afterwards he obtained confidence through experience, and delivered praiseworthy instruction extempore. His sermons, however, were never such as would be put in writing by hearers."⁷

⁴ Oratio 42. P. G. 36, 492.

⁵ Historia Ecclesiastica, 6, 4. P. G. 67, 672.

⁶ Historia Ecclesiastica, 7, 2. P. G. 67.

⁷ Historia Tripartita, 11, 2. P. L. 69, 1188.

Evidence for the presence of *notarii* in the church is no less striking among the Latin fathers. Gaudentius, bishop of Brixia, says in the preface of his tractates to Benevolus, "Regarding those sermons which, broken and incomplete, were taken down by stenographers present in secret, and which the useless zeal of some has presumed to collect, with those I am in no way concerned. Those, which it is well known were taken down with reckless haste, are not mine."⁸

The titles of the sixteenth and seventeenth sermons of this same Gaudentius give similar testimony. The title of the sixteenth reads: "In eo quod S. Episcopum prima die ordinationis ipsius quorundam civium notarii exceperunt."⁹ Codex Galeardus has for the heading of the seventeenth: "Tractatus eiusdem exceptus die dedicationis basilicae concilii sanctorum incipit."¹⁰

No obscure mention of the *notarii* present in the church is made by Gregory the Great. Writing to Marianus the bishop regarding his homilies on Ezekiel, he says: "The sermons which I gave on the holy prophet Ezekiel and which were taken down as I spoke to the people, I had left in suspension because of many pressing cares. But after eight years, at the request of my brothers, I decided to look on the papers of the *notarii* and as I ran over them I emended such as I was permitted through the grace of God to rescue from tribulations."¹¹

In another connection we have already quoted part of the prologue to Gregory's forty homilies on the gospel where he mentions the *notarii* in the church taking down his sermons.¹² A little farther on, Gregory adds, "Because indeed some have been placed first, which are read later in the gospel and others are found last which were written before, you ought by no means to change the order, my brethren, because they are arranged just as they were spoken by me at various times, and just too as they were placed in the codices by the stenographers." Finally in a letter to the Bishop Leandorus, which he prefixed to his expositions of Job, Gregory writes as follows: "Although

⁸ P. L. 20, 831.

⁹ P. L. 20, 955.

¹⁰ P. L. 20, 959.

¹¹ P. L. 76, 785, Preface to his homilies on Ezekiel.

¹² P. L. 76, 1075.

my life far surpasses the lives of those to whom I was bound to administer, I did not consider it harmful if my fluent pencil tended to the needs of men. Thus sometimes when my brothers were in my very presence, I spoke the beginning of some work; and then when I found time a little heavier on my hands I treated and dictated a later portion. And when still more time was available to me, I added much to my works, took away a little, and left a great deal as I found it; and by emending thus whatever had been taken down as I spoke I formed complete works.”¹³

From these few selections taken at random, it is evident that it was by no means the unusual but rather the regular custom for *notarii* to be present in the important churches to take down unwritten sermons as they were being delivered.

V. AUGUSTINE'S REGULAR PRACTICE OF DELIVERING SERMONS WITHOUT ANY WRITTEN ASSISTANCE, AND SOMETIMES WITHOUT ANY PREVIOUS PREPARATION.

That part of the traditional view which declared that Augustine wrote or dictated many of his sermons has already been shown to rest on very meagre and questionable evidence.¹ A great deal of testimony does exist, however, as to the manner in which the Bishop of Hippo composed and delivered his discourses.

Augustine's great work on the art of preaching is his *De Doctrina Christiana*. This treatise of four books is divided into two parts, the first (books 1-3) dealing with the discovery of the true sense of the Scripture, the second (book 4) treating of its expression.

It is very noteworthy that throughout the fourth book Augustine assumes speaking and not reading as the manner of addressing a congregation. Several quotations will serve to make our point clear. Augustine says that it is lawful for a Christian teacher to use the art of rhetoric, for the art of rhetoric being available for the enforcing of either truth or falsehood, who will dare say that truth in the person of its defenders is to take

¹³ P. L. 75, 512.

¹ Cf. Introduction.

its stand unarmed against falsehood? Furthermore, the rules of rhetoric must be learned quickly (*celeriter*). "If, however, such ability be wanting, the rules of rhetoric are either not understood, or if, impressed on the mind with great labor, they come to be in some small measure understood, they prove of no service. For even those who have learnt them, and who speak with fluency and eloquence, *cannot always think of them when they are speaking so as to speak in accordance with them, unless they are discussing the rules themselves. Indeed, I think there are scarcely any who can do both things—that is, speak well, and, in order to do this, think of the rules of speaking while they are speaking. For we must be careful that what we have got to say does not escape us whilst we are thinking about saying it according to the rules of art.* Nevertheless, in the speeches of eloquent men, we find rules of eloquence carried out which the speakers did not think of as aids to eloquence at the time when they were speaking, whether they had ever learned them, or whether they never even met with them. For it is because they are eloquent that they exemplify these rules; it is not that they use them in order to be eloquent."²

"If the hearers need teaching, the matter treated of must be made fully known by means of narrative. On the other hand, to clear up points that are doubtful requires reasoning and exhibition of proofs. If, however, the hearers require to be roused rather than instructed, in order that they may be diligent to do what they already know, and to bring their feelings into harmony with the truths they admit, greater vigor is needed. Here entreaties and reproaches and upbraidings, and all other means of rousing the emotions, are necessary."³

"Now it is specially necessary for the man who is bound to speak wisely, even though he cannot speak eloquently, to retain in memory the words of Scripture. For the more he discerns the poverty of his own speech, the more he ought to draw on the riches of the Scripture, so that what he says in his own words he may prove by the words of Scripture, and he himself, though small and weak in his own words, may gain strength and power from the confirming testimony of great men. For

² 4, 3 and 4.³ 4, 6.

his proof gives pleasure when he cannot please by his mode of speech.”⁴

“And this (perspicuity of style) must be insisted on as necessary to our being understood not only in conversation, whether with one person or with several, but much more in the case of a speech delivered in public: for in conversation anyone has the power of asking a question; but when all are silent that one may be heard, and all faces are turned attentively upon him, it is neither customary nor decorous for a person to ask a question about what he does not understand; and on this account the speaker ought to be especially careful to give assistance to those who cannot ask it. *Now a crowd anxious for instruction generally shows by its movements if it understands what is said, and until some indication of this sort be given, the subject discussed ought to be turned over and over, and put in every shape and form and variety of expression, a thing which cannot be done by men who are repeating words prepared beforehand and committed to memory. As soon, however, as the speaker has ascertained that what he says is understood, he ought either to bring his address to a close or pass on to another point. For if a man gives pleasure when he throws light upon points on which people wish instruction, he becomes wearisome when he dwells at length upon things that are already well known, especially when men's expectations were fixed on having the difficulties of the passage removed.*”⁵

In the last part of the *De Doctrina Christiana*,⁶ Augustine mentions those who memorize or simply read the speeches of others, but he does so entirely as a condescension. He says in part that there are some men who have a good delivery, but cannot compose anything to deliver. Now it is permissible for such men to take what has been written with wisdom and eloquence by others, and commit it to memory and deliver it to the people, provided they do it openly. In this way, he says, many become preachers of the truth, which is very desirable, but not many become teachers; for in reality they are all delivering the discourses which only one real teacher has composed.

Throughout his work *De Catechizandis Rudibus*, Augustine

⁴ 4, 8.

⁵ 4, 25.

⁶ 4, 29 and 30. Cf. Chapter II.

speaks of the manner of preaching to be employed in addressing the uninstructed. Here too he always assumes speaking, naturally extempore, as the proper method of preaching in the church.

Thus in discussing the fact that it often happens that a discourse which gives pleasure to the hearer is distasteful to the speaker, he says, "Indeed with me too, it is almost always the fact that my speech displeases myself. For I am covetous of something better, the possession of which I frequently enjoy within me before I commence to body it forth in intelligible words: and then when my capacities of expression prove inferior to my inner apprehensions, I grieve over the inability which my tongue has betrayed in answering to my heart. For it is my wish that he who hears me should have the same complete understanding of the subject which I myself have; and I perceive that I fail to speak in a manner calculated to effect that, and that this arises mainly from the circumstance that the intellectual apprehension diffuses itself through the mind with something like a rapid flash, whereas the utterance is slow, and occupies time, and is of a vastly different nature, so that, while this latter is moving on, the intellectual apprehension has already withdrawn itself within its secret abode." He says that often in his desire to express himself in exact accordance with his intellectual apprehension at the time, he fails while engaged in the very effort. Accordingly he becomes discouraged and wearied, and the discourse itself becomes even more languid and pointless than it was when it first caused him such a sense of tediousness.⁷

Augustine says further, "*But oftentimes the earnestness of those who are desirous of hearing me shows me that my utterance is not so frigid as it seems to myself to be. From the delight, too, which they exhibit, I gather that they derive some profit from it. And I occupy myself sedulously with the endeavor not to fail in putting before them a service in which I perceive them to take in such good part what is put before them.*" Augustine continues to say that a person is listened to with much greater satisfaction when he himself takes pleasure in his work, because his very words are affected by the joy which he

shares in pronouncing them. Accordingly it is comparatively easy to lay down rules as to where narration should commence and end, how it should be varied, etc.; but how it shall be done so that one may have pleasure in his work when he catechizes, for on this largely depends his success, that requires the greatest consideration.”⁸

In giving some reasons why one's speech seems so weak and inferior to one's thoughts, Augustine says, “because our intelligence is better pleased and more thoroughly arrested by that which we perceive in silence in the mind, and because we have no inclination to have our attention called off from it to a noise of words coming far short of representing it; or from the circumstance that even when discourse is pleasant, *we have more delight in hearing or reading things which have been expressed in a superior manner, and which are set forth without any care or anxiety on our part, than putting together, with a view to the comprehension of others, words suddenly conceived, and leaving it an uncertain issue, on the one hand, whether such terms occur to us as adequately represent the sense and, on the other, whether they be accepted in such a manner as to profit.*”⁹

As Augustine goes on discussing the various remedies to be applied to a weary audience, he says, “*But in a good truth it is a serious demand to make upon us, to continue discoursing on to the set limit when we fail to see our hearers in any degree moved; whether it be that, under the restraints of the awe of religion, he has not the boldness to signify his approval by voice, or by any movement of his body, or that he is kept back by the modesty proper to man, or that he does not understand our sayings, or that he counts them of no value. Since, then, this must be a matter of uncertainty to us, as we cannot discern his mind, it becomes our duty in our discourse to make trial of all things which may be of any avail in stirring him up and drawing him forth as it were from his place of concealment.*”¹⁰

“It is likewise a frequent occurrence,” says Augustine, “that one who at first listened to us with all readiness, becomes exhausted either by the effort of hearing or by standing, and now no longer commends what is said but gapes and yawns, and, though unwillingly, exhibits a disposition to depart. When we

⁸ 4.⁹ 14.¹⁰ 18.

observe that, it becomes our duty to refresh his mind by saying something seasoned with an honest cheerfulness and adapted to the matter which is being discussed, or something of a very wonderful and amazing order, or even, it may be, something of a painful and mournful nature. Whatever we say thus may be all the better if it affects him himself more immediately, so that the quick sense of self-concern may keep his attention on the alert." However, we should be careful not to offend but rather conciliate, he says. We may even offer our congregation seats, especially if it is small and appears heedless. Or we may say something very striking to bring them away from the cause of their inattention.¹¹

Augustine says further, "I wish you to keep in mind the fact that the mental effort is of one kind in the case of the person who dictates, with a future reader in his view, and that it is of quite another kind in the case of a person who speaks with a present hearer to whom to direct his attention. And further, it is to be remembered that, in this latter instance, in particular, the effort is of one kind, when one is admonishing in private, and when there is no other person at hand to pronounce judgment on us; whereas it is of a different order when one is conveying any instruction in public, and when there stand around him an audience of persons holding dissimilar opinions; and again, that in this exercise of teaching, the effort will be of one sort when only a single individual is being instructed, while all the rest listen, like persons judging or attesting things well known to them, and that it will be different when all those who are present wait for what we have to deliver to them; and once more, that, in this same instance, the effort will be one thing when all are seated, as it were, in private conference with a view to engaging in some discussion, and that it will be quite another thing when the people sit silent and intent on giving attention to some single speaker who is to address them from a higher position." He continues that it will likewise make a difference in one's discourse whether one is addressing few or many; learned or unlearned, or both classes combined; city-bred or rustics, or both mingled together; or whether again the audience is composed of all classes of men in

¹¹ 19.

due proportion. All such situations are bound to affect the speaker in different ways, and influence his ways, and accordingly produce different effects on the congregation. "I am a witness to you, as regards my own experience," says Augustine, "*that I find myself variously moved, according as I see before me for the purpose of catechetical instruction, a highly educated man, a poor man, a private individual, a man of honors, a person occupying some position of authority, an individual of this or another nation, of this or another age or sex, one proceeding from this or another sect, from this or another common error,—and ever in accordance with the difference of my feelings does my discourse itself set out, go on, and reach its end.*"¹²

Beginning with section 24, Augustine presents a type sermon, such as he himself would give to catechumens.¹³ It is remarkable how this discourse lacks the liveliness and the vividness common to his regular sermons. This deficiency may be due partly to its being merely a sermon for illustration, but chiefly, we feel sure, to its being a carefully written discourse, i. e. written as he was dictating the entire work of the *De Catechizandis Rudibus*, and not delivered without written assistance and recorded at the moment, as we have every reason to believe that his regular sermons were.¹⁴

We have already had occasion to quote the last sentence of the *Retractations* where according to the correct reading Augustine speaks of his letters as *dictatas* and his sermons as *dictos*.¹⁵ Possidius in his life of Augustine says: "In private and in public, at home and in the church, Augustine taught and preached the word of salvation both by his finished books and by extemporaneous sermons."¹⁶ *Confectus* meaning "composed," "written," "finished," or "elaborate" was in common use

¹² 23.¹⁴ Cf. Chapter VII.¹³ Cf. 51, and end of 23.¹⁵ Cf. Introduction.

¹⁶ Et docebat ac praeedicabat ille privatim et publice in domo et in ecclesia salutis verbum libris confectis et repentinis sermonibus. Much information on Augustine's manner of preaching is obtained from the *Vita S. Aurelii Augustini* of Possidius, Bishop of Guelma. This is a most trustworthy source, because Possidius was on very intimate terms with Augustine for forty years, and expressly says that he is relating only what he has actually seen and heard.

even in classical times.¹⁷ In this statement from Possidius, *confectis* stands in sharp contrast with *repentinis*, which can scarcely mean anything else than "not prepared before in writing" (lit. "sudden").¹⁸

Possidius tells also of an incident which gives added testimony as to the manner in which Augustine preached. On returning one day from the church to his group of pupils, Augustine remarked: "Did you take notice that both the beginning and the ending of my sermon in the church today worked out contrary to my usual custom? For I did not explain to its conclusion the subject which I had propounded, but left it in suspense." "I suppose that perhaps the Lord wished some wanderer among the people to be taught and healed by our forgetfulness and error; for in His hands are we and all our utterances. For while I was investigating the margins of the question proposed, by a digression of speech I passed over to something else, and so, without finishing or explaining the question, I ended my discourse by attacking the error of the Manichaeans—about which I had intended to say nothing in my discussion—rather than by speaking about those things which I had intended to explain."¹⁹ Possidius relates further that on the very next day, a merchant, Firmus by name, appeared begging to be taken into the true fold and away from the Manichaeans.

In a letter to his bosom friend Alypius, Bishop of Tagaste,²⁰ Augustine gives another instance of his speaking extempore, or with but slight previous meditation on the subject. He says, "We must not fail to inform your charity of what was done, that with us you may give thanks to God for the favor received, in behalf of which your prayers were united with ours. Soon after your departure, it was announced that the men were tumultuous, and said they could not suffer that feast to be abolished, from which, by calling it Laetitia, they vainly attempted, as you were informed when present, to remove the idea

¹⁷ Cf. Cicero Att. 6, 7, 2; Cicero Fam. 3, 11, 4; Caesar B. G. 1, 29; Quintilian 10, 1, 19; Nepos Att. 18, 6; Nepos Hann. 13.

¹⁸ The meaning of *repentini* is clearly illustrated in a letter of Sidonius Apollinaris to Pope Faustus. Cf. Chapter II.

¹⁹ 15.

²⁰ 2, 37 (Augustini Opera).

of drunkenness. By the secret council of Almighty God, it happened very opportunely for us, that on Wednesday that portion of the Gospel was to be treated of in the course of which He says, "Give not that which is holy unto the dogs, neither cast ye your pearls before swine." I enlarged upon the crime of drunkenness as far as time would permit, and took up the apostle Paul," etc.

In one of his sermons, Augustine shows clearly that he was in the habit of thinking out his sermon beforehand, but not of writing it down. He says, "*ego qui vobiscum loquor, antequam ad vos venirem, cogitavi ante quod vobis dicerem. Quando cogitavi quod vobis dicerem, iam in corde meo verbum erat. Non enim vobis dicerem, nisi ante cogitarem.*"²¹

Augustine, however, often did speak entirely extempore. If we had no definite testimony to that effect, we could hardly doubt his ability to do so, if we considered his ideas on the manner of expressing the truths of Scripture; the emphasis he lays on speaking, not reading, sermons, and on watching the audience for evidence of its proper understanding of the truths expounded, and on noting the various effects of one's words on the hearers with a corresponding adaptation of the process of the sermon. The man who could preach successfully in this way would certainly be able to preach strictly extempore if the occasion demanded.

There are several sermons, however, in which Augustine tells his congregation quite frankly that he has been inspired with the subject of his present sermon while listening to the reading of the Gospel, and must accordingly improvise.²² These discourses, it must be confessed, do not differ markedly from the average run of Augustine's homilies. Yet in the case of such a constant preacher as Augustine, it is difficult to class any sermon as purely extempore, since he must have been more or less prepared to expound any well-known text of the Scripture.

We may say then that Augustine delivered his sermons without any written assistance, after having first meditated on his text more or less. Too much emphasis cannot be laid on the fact that there is not the slightest reason to believe that Augustine ever wrote (or dictated) a sermon, and then read it or

²¹ 225, 3.

²² See Chapter VI.

delivered it from memory. Indeed every statement of Augustine himself excludes the idea.

VI. AUGUSTINE'S CONSTANT USE OF THE NOTARIUS IN EVERY PHASE OF HIS LITERARY ACTIVITY.

Augustine's sermons were recorded and have been preserved to us through the ecclesiastical shorthand writers. That *notarii* were present in the church when Augustine preached is expressly stated by Possidius. He says, "Even the heretics themselves gathered together and listened with the Catholics most eagerly to these books and treatises which issued and flowed forth by the wonderful grace of God, filled with abundance of reason and the authority of Holy Scripture; each one also who would or could, bringing reporters and taking down what was said."¹ And, "The Donatists, in particular, who lived in Hippo and the neighboring towns, brought his addresses and writings to their bishops."²

Augustine, too, in a letter to the consuls Theodosius and Valentinianus, speaks of the *Notarii Ecclesiae*. In this letter he quotes from one of his sermons delivered previously, in which he specially called the attention of his audience to the fact that *notarii* were taking down his words and their exclamations of applause.³

This common use of the *notarius* in the churches of other early fathers has already been discussed,⁴ but in a letter written jointly with Alypius to Aurelius, Bishop of Carthage, Augustine seems to show that it was customary among preachers of the time to leave the shorthand reports of their sermons untranscribed until they saw fit to make use of them. In this letter, Augustine congratulates Aurelius on the excellent sermons which the priests gave in his presence and begs that some of them be sent to him. He says, "Obsecramus te per eum qui tibi ista donavit, et populum, cui servis, hac per te bene-

¹ 7.

² 9.

³ 213. A Notariis Ecclesiae, sicut cernitis, excipiuntur quae dicimus, excipiuntur quae dicitis, et meus sermo et vestrae acclamationes in terram non cadunt.

⁴ Cf. Chapter III.

dictione perfudit, ut iubeas singulos quos volueris sermones eorum conscriptos, et emendatos mitti nobis.”⁵ The words *conscriptos* and *emendatos* in this connection naturally mean to be written up from the shorthand reports with whatever changes the preacher desired in his more or less extemporaneous and so perhaps careless statements.

Degert (*loc. cit.*) makes a great deal of a passage from Possidius to support his belief that Augustine wrote out most of his sermons before delivery. The words of Possidius are, “Tanta autem ab eodem dictata et edita sunt, tantaque in ecclesia disputata, excepta atque emendata, vel adversus diversos haereticos, vel ex canonicis libris exposita ad aedificationem sanctorum ecclesiae filiorum, ut ea omnia vix quisquam studiosorum perlegere et nosse sufficiat.”⁶ Possidius however distinguishes clearly here between Augustine’s finished works, dictated (*dictata*) and published (*edita*), and his disputations in the churches, taken down (*excepta*) and emended (*emendata*). The sense here regarding Augustine’s disputations or sermons is clearly the same as that respecting the sermons which Augustine himself speaks of in the passage quoted just above. The discourses were taken down by *notarii*, transcribed from the shorthand notes, and emended before circulation.

Augustine’s entire life was very intimately connected with the shorthand writers. That he made use of *notarii* in the privacy of his study, is attested not only by frequent allusions to them, often by name, in his own writings,⁷ but also by the statements of Possidius. The latter says, “But when such things had been arranged and set in order, then, as though freed from consuming and annoying cares, his soul rebounded to the more intimate and lofty thoughts of the mind in order either to ponder on the discovery of divine truth or to dictate some of the things already discovered or else to emend some of the works which had been previously dictated and then transcribed.”⁸

The intimate and important position of the *notarius* in the life of Augustine and his friends is shown by the manner in

⁵ 41, 2.

⁶ 18.

⁷ Cf. P. L. (Opera Augustini) 2, 26; 2, 488; 2, 490; 3, 55; 9, 807; etc.

⁸ 24. Cf. also 18, quoted above.

which they speak of the shorthand writer in their private correspondence. Thus, to cite only a few out of many passages of this sort, Jerome writes to Augustine and laments the lack, in Palestine, of *notarii* that have a good knowledge of Latin.⁹ Evodius writes to Augustine in much distress over the loss of a particularly bright *notarius*.¹⁰ In one instance Augustine has just received a letter from a certain Seleuciana, in which he is informed of the very curious theological opinion of one of his acquaintances. In answering this letter, Augustine, unable to believe that the person in question could have entertained such a belief, suggests that the *notarius* has taken down the letter from dictation inaccurately, or has deliberately falsified the note when copying it into longhand. The possibility of his friend's not having a *notarius* does not enter his mind.¹¹ Furthermore the discussions of Augustine with his associates at Cassiciacum, taken down by the ever-present *notarius*, form the substance of the books "Against the Academics," "On the Order of Providence," and "On the Happy Life."¹²

Not only did Augustine employ the *notarius* for the well-known duties of the scholar's secretary, but he also found him indispensable for reporting his oral debates with heretics. In such cases the *notarii* acted officially just as court stenographers do today. It was indeed from these shorthand records that Augustine was later able to make the compendium of his various public debates with the Donatists, which now exists under the name, "*Breviculus collationis cum Donatistis*."¹³

Possidius, in recounting the various public debates in which

* P. L. 33, 753. Grandem Latini sermonis in ista provincia notariorum patimur penuriam; et ideo praeceptis tuis parere non possumus, maxime in editione Septuaginta, quae asteriscis verubusque distincta est.

¹⁰ P. L. 33, 694. Erat strenuus in notis, et in scribendo bene laboriosus, studiosus quoque esse coeperat lectionis, ut ipse meam tarditatem causa legendi nocturnis horis exhortaretur. Coeperam eum non quasi puerum et notarium habere, sed amicum quemdam satis necessarium et suavem.

¹¹ P. L. 33, 1085. Si enim notarius non mendose excepit aut scripsit, nescio quale cor habeat qui cum Apostolos baptizatos dicat, Petrum baptizatum negat.

¹² Cf. De Ordine, 1, 5.

¹³ P. L. 43.

his venerated teacher took part, rarely fails to mention either the *notarius* or his art. Thus a certain *domus regiae procurator* at Carthage discovered a clandestine gathering of Manichaeans, whom he immediately took to a board of bishops and had examined *ad tabulas*.¹⁴ Among these bishops was Augustine himself.¹⁵ Similarly, regarding Augustine's controversies with the Manichaeans Fortunatus (392) and Felix (404), Possidius says, "Unde conducto die et loco convenerunt in unum, concurrentibus quam plurimis studiosis turbisque curiosis, et apertis notarii tabulis disputatio coepta primo, et secundo finita est die."¹⁶ And also, "Cum quodam etiam Felice de numero eorum quos electos dicunt Manichaei, publice in Hipponensi ecclesia notariis excipientibus disputavit populo astante."¹⁷

Pascentius, the Arian, once engaged Augustine in a public debate, but contrary to the usual custom, positively forbade the use of the tablets and stylus.¹⁸ Later (427 or 428) Augustine overcame the Arian bishop Maximinus in public debate. From the shorthand accounts of this meeting Augustine was afterwards obliged to publish a recapitulation, since Maximinus had succeeded in spreading incorrect reports about the encounter.¹⁹

The public debates with the Donatists, however, furnish us with the most interesting incidents regarding this use of *notarii*. The Donatist bishop Emeritus was refuted in public debate, and indeed remained silent so long in the midst of his speech that finally the *notarius* himself urged him to continue.²⁰ Augustine himself tells us of a striking incident which occurred at his public debate with the Donatist bishop Fortunatus. The regular *notarii*, for some unknown reason, refused to serve at the contest, regardless of any sort of inducement. Volunteers were summoned from the audience. These, although willing

¹⁴ *Ad tabulas; notariis excipientibus et in tabulas inferentibus interrogata et responsa.* Note in Huerta's edition, page 36.

¹⁵ 16.

¹⁶ 6.

¹⁷ 16.

¹⁸ Possidius, 17. Sed idem haereticus tabulas atque stilum, quod magister noster et ante congressum, et in congressu instantissime fieri volebat, ne adessent omni modo recusat.

¹⁹ Cf. Possidius, 17.

²⁰ Possidius, 16. Et alio loco, dum a notario, ut responderet, admoneretur et reticeret, eius cunctis manifestata diffidentia, Ecclesiae Dei augmenta ac firmamenta provenerunt.

enough, were utterly unable to keep up with the rapid speech of the contestants and were finally obliged to stop writing.²¹ Shorthand experts were employed in behalf of the state as well as the church at the famous conference of Catholic and Donatist bishops at Carthage in 411. Augustine says a great deal in this connection in his public letter summoning all Donatists to the true Church. That part of the letter in which we are interested reads: "Both your bishops and we arrived in Carthage, and, although they were before unwilling and said it was not in accordance with their dignity, we all met. Seven were selected from our number and seven from theirs who were to be representatives in the debate. Then seven more were chosen from each party, with whom the former seven were to take counsel when there was need. Then four were selected from each side to have charge of writing up the proceedings, lest some falsehood be inserted by somebody. Four stenographers also were given by each party to alternate two at a time in doing the work of the judge's stenographers, lest some one of us pretend that something was said which was not taken down. To this great care another caution was added, that both they and we should, just as the judge himself, subscribe to our words, lest some one say afterwards that there had been some meddling, etc., etc."²²

Thus did Augustine use the *notarius* in his various works, his sermons, letters, debates, and finished productions, and it is hard to believe that the bishop of Hippo himself, one of the busiest of men both in literary and administrative ways, ever performed the mechanical task of mere writing in connection with his literary productions except in the most incidental way. We know that his sermons were taken down by *notarii* as he delivered them. Are we to believe that he performed the mechanical task of copying the shorthand?

(To be continued.)

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²¹ Ep. 44.

²² Ep. 141, 2. Cf. also *Excerpta ad Donatistarum historiam pertinentia*. P. L. 43, 816, 820.